DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

How Should We Study Torah?

Derech Hashem 4:2:5-6

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 2, paragraphs 5-6 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 24 January 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap

Last week: the purpose of Torah study is not only to know what to do, but also to bring perfection, because God tied within Torah study a deep influence. We connect to it in two ways, by reading the text, especially the twenty-four books of Tanakh in Hebrew, or by understanding it, and best by both. Mishnah and Gemara are the intellectual explanation of Tanakh, where the main influence is stored. And one must have a share in every part of Torah.

A participant asked how this relates to the idea that the misvot correspond to the limbs of the body. The Rabbi explained that the rectification brought by Torah study is not only of the individual person, limb by limb, but of the whole of creation: a more holistic tikkun.

Paragraph 5: the first condition, reverence

All of this depends on studying Torah properly. The conditions are two: fear and awe during study, and a constant effort to improve one's conduct. One applies within the learning, the other outside it.

Why? The whole power of Torah comes only from the fact that God tied His light into it. Without that, reading Torah would be like reading any other literature, a novel, a science book or a philosophy book: you would gain knowledge, but it would have no real effect on the soul or on creation.

The Rabbi pointed to a key line. Do you remember, from Part 1, chapter 5, the whole chain of worlds through which energy passes? Torah is the only thing that brings the light down directly, "from Him to you", without passing through the chain. When you shake the lulav, the energy is diluted on the way. With Torah it is not. "Therefore you have to tremble." A person should feel his own smallness before God's exaltedness, and at the same time delight in the opportunity to learn.

This means not studying with frivolity, "like you're reading a novel or you're watching a film". Treat the books with respect: do not throw them around or leave them on the floor, do not slouch, do not take Torah books into the bathroom. Recognise before Whom you are studying. If that is lacking, nothing comes down, and your learning is like any university lecture, "a

degree in biblical studies". It may even be worse: drawing near to the holy without awe can be considered a wrong in itself. The more reverence, the more influence.

Quality, not quantity

The Rabbi brought the Nefesh HaHayim of Rabbi Hayim of Volozhin. Although we must not neglect Torah study, a person who pauses in the middle of learning to regather his thoughts and remind himself why he is learning is not committing bittul Torah. On the contrary: *bittulah zehu kiyumah*, its neglect is its fulfilment. Twelve hours of learning without awareness of what one is doing does not compare to ten hours with that awareness. "It's quality, not quantity."

Paragraph 6: the second condition, character

The second condition is constantly improving one's deeds. One who wants to draw down this light must be a fit vessel for it. A person who defiles himself with sins and strays after impurity is told, "What right have you to recite My laws?" The Gemara in Hullin says that teaching an unworthy student is like throwing a stone to Markulis, the idol worshipped by throwing stones.

So character matters: impure thoughts, bad traits, arrogance, all of it. The Rabbi added that although there is no halachic requirement to go to the mikveh during the year, it is a good practice every so often for one engaged in bringing down this light.

But do not stop learning

Even so, Hazal revealed a great secret: even a complete rasha should not leave the Torah. However bad his deeds, if he keeps some connection, a tiny drop of light, a shadow of illumination, can grow over time and bring him back. As Hazal put it in God's name, would that they had left Me but kept My Torah. "However bad you are, stick to the Torah. It will bring you back."

The crucial last lines

But this applies only to someone who studies Torah like any other discipline, for knowledge, money or honour. That is *shelo lishmah*, not ideal, but fine: keep going. It does not apply to one who studies in order to mock, to pervert the meaning of Torah, or to catch others out.

The Rabbi set out the famous contradiction. The Gemara says a person should always learn even *shelo lishmah*, because from it he will come to *lishmah*. Yet the Gemara in Berakhot says that for one who learns *shelo lishmah*, it would be better had he not been born. Tosafot resolve it: the first is learning for honour or money, which leads to lishmah; the second is learning *lekanter*, to mock and to provoke. "If you're going to learn to mock, you're going to learn to pervert, you're going to learn to catch other people out, don't learn at all." He planned to develop this further.

Summary

- Torah study draws God's light down directly, without the chain of worlds, so it demands awe.
- Learned without reverence, Torah is like any other textbook, and may even be harmful.

- Pausing to remember why we learn is not bittul Torah but its fulfilment: quality over quantity.
- The second condition is constant improvement of character.
- Even a sinner should keep learning, unless he learns in order to mock or distort.

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